

Toss or Hold'em

We **strongly recommend** learning the rules of Texas Hold'em before learning Toss or Hold'em. Two helpful resources are pkr.bot/poker-rules and pkr.bot/poker-video.

Overview

The poker variant for the 6.9630 Pokerbots Competition in IAP 2026 is "Toss or Hold'em," a game based on the popular poker variant No-Limit Texas Hold'em. The main modifications are as follows: each player starts with 3 pre-discard hole cards. The flop is two cards, and after the flop has been dealt out but before flop betting, each player (sequentially) chooses to "discard" one of their three hole cards and move them to the board cards (so that after discarding, each player has 2 post-discard hole cards and there are 4 board cards). Any discarded cards are public information as they now function as normal public-use board cards. The turn and river then happen normally, so that (without folding), there are 6 board cards by showdown. Showdown is still evaluated by each player's best 5-card hand.

It is important to note that at every round of play, the players' stack sizes are reset to 400.

Another useful observation is when a player discards one of their pre-discard hole cards, it gets moved to the board, meaning the player still retains access to it when making their best 5-card hand. However, the villain also has access to that card now.

Glossary

Pre-discard hole cards	A player's 3 private cards, prior to discarding one card to the board during the flop
Post-discard hole cards	A player's 2 private cards, after discarding one card to the board during the flop
Board cards	Cards that are public and shared between the players
Pot	The accumulation of bets and other payments made by the players during a round to be claimed by the winner of the round
Stack	A player's individual resources they use for bets and other payments during a round
Pip	A player's contribution so far to the pot during a round of betting
Blinds	Small, forced bets at the beginning of the round to kick off the pot
Call	A minimum pot contribution to stay in the round in response to a bet or raise

Check	A “pass” or bet of 0
Fold	To quit the round and let the other player claim the pot
Flop	When the first two board cards are dealt.
Discard Round (aka Toss Round)	When the players sequentially (dealer’s opponent aka out of position goes first) discard one of their pre-discard hole cards and moves it to be a board card during the flop. Flop betting occurs after both discards occur.
Turn	When the fifth board card is dealt
Showdown	When the players’ post-discard hole cards are revealed to determine the winner of the round who claims the pot

Game Logistics

A game of Toss or Hold’em consists of a number of rounds played between two players. In every round, each player is allocated a stack before the cards are dealt. The change in a player’s stack at the end of the round is used to update that player’s bankroll, which starts at 0. The player with the highest cumulative bankroll after the last round is played wins the game.

Parameters

Rounds: 1000

Stack allocated per round: 400

Big blind: 2

Small blind: 1

Sequence of Play

A round of No-Limit Toss or Hold’em has all the stages as standard Texas Hold’em, with the exception of dealing pre-discard hole cards before the flop as well as the discard round.

1. Pay blinds
2. **Deal pre-discard hole cards**
3. Round of betting
4. Deal flop
5. **Discard round**
6. Round of betting
7. Deal turn
8. Round of betting
9. Deal river
10. Round of betting
11. Showdown

Deal

Three pre-discard hole cards are dealt after the blinds.

Only two board cards are dealt after the flop initially. After discarding, there will be four board cards.

The turn and river deals are the same as in standard Texas Hold'em.

Blinds

In each round, one player is designated as the dealer. The dealer alternates between successive rounds. To start the round, the dealer pays the small blind and their opponent pays the big blind. The blinds are a mandatory bet of 1 by the dealer followed by a mandatory raise to 2 by their opponent, which leaves the dealer to act next.

Betting

In the first round of betting (labeled 3 above), the dealer is the first player to act. In this first action, the dealer may fold (cost: 0), call (cost: 1), or raise (cost: 3+).

In all other rounds of betting, the dealer's opponent is the first player to act. In this action, the player may check (cost: 0) or bet (cost: 2+). The minimum legal bet is 1 big blind. The maximum legal bet is bounded by both players' remaining stack sizes; this ensures that neither player can make a bet that their opponent is unable to call.

When a player is faced with a bet or raise from their opponent, that player is allowed to raise. There is no limit on the number of consecutive raises that may occur in a round of betting.

The raise amount is defined as the amount by which the raising player's pip exceeds their opponent's pip. Equivalently, this is the opponent's cost of calling after the raise. It is common in Hold'em to place restrictions on the raise amount in order for a raise to be legal.

In Toss or Hold'em, the minimum legal raise amount follows the same rules as standard No-Limit Texas Hold'em: the size of the previous bet if responding to a bet or the previous raise amount if responding to a raise. The maximum legal raise amount is bounded by both players' remaining stack sizes so that neither player can make a raise that their opponent is unable to call.

If the remaining stack sizes do not allow for a minimum legal raise amount, i.e. the maximum is below the minimum, then the only legal raise is the maximum legal raise amount. This occurs when a player makes an all-in raise.

The round of betting ends when a player calls, when a player folds, or when both players check in a row. In the first round of betting, if the dealer calls right away, then the round does not end and their opponent is given the opportunity to act: check (cost: 0) or raise (cost: 2+).

These are the standard Texas Hold'em betting rules; we encourage those unfamiliar with betting in Hold'em to revisit the resources pkr.bot/poker-rules and pkr.bot/poker-video for a refresher.

Discarding

As discussed earlier, both players are dealt 3 pre-discard hole cards after the blinds are posted. Pre-flop betting then occurs with these 3 cards in hand.

The flop will be 2 board cards and goes directly into the Discard round. The players **sequentially** discard one of their 3 pre-discard hole cards, with the **dealer's opponent/out of position discarding first. All discarded cards are public information.** Thus, the dealer will see 3 cards on the board (including their opponent's discarded card) when they are deciding which of their cards to discard. After both players have discarded, there will be 4 board cards.

Example of play:

A (dealer) and B (out of position)

A posts small blind: 1

B posts big blind: 2

A is dealt: 3 of Hearts, 4 of Hearts, J of Diamonds

B is dealt: K of Clubs, Q of Spades, J of Hearts

A calls

B checks

Flop is dealt with board cards: 7 of Hearts, 2 of Hearts

B is out of position and must discard first

B discards J of Hearts

Updated flop: 7 of Hearts, 2 of Hearts, J of Hearts

A must discard

- Note the J of Hearts is visible to A while A decides what to discard
- Also note A has a flush at this point because of the new J of Hearts board card

A discards J of Diamonds

Updated flop: 7 of Hearts, 2 of Hearts, J of Hearts, J of Diamonds

A's post-discard hole cards: 3 of Hearts, 4 of Hearts

B's post-discard hole cards: K of Clubs, Q of Spades

B checks

A bets 2

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(Remainder proceeds as in typical Texas Hold'em, except with a 5th board card dealt during the turn and a 6th board card dealt during the river)

Showdown

The winner of the round is determined by the standard Texas Hold'em hand scorings. Just as in regular Texas Hold'em, players may use any of the board cards in addition to their own hole cards to make their best possible five-card hand. Player's bankrolls are updated based off of the winning player. In the case of a tie, players' bankrolls do not change.